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Since these fortresses were intended primarily for members of the royal family, it is natural that they also contained wings suited to the latter's standard of living and life-style. However, it should be mentioned that the sojourns of the king's relatives were not necessarily always of their own free choice. According to the testimony of Josephus, on several occasions members of the royal house who were rebellious either in character or deed were sent to the fortresses to be kept in isolation. Herod, on the other hand, sent his wife to one of these fortresses (Alexandrium) when he went abroad and was concerned about her safety or actions in his absence.²

To date clear evidence of the existence of palatial wings within the framework of the desert fortresses has been revealed at the following sites: Alexandrium (Sartaba), to the east of the Samaritan Hills; Cypros, to the southwest of Jericho; and Machaerus, to the east of the Dead Sea, roughly opposite the oasis of En Gedi. The large number of palaces discovered at Masada has not been

included in this list, as two separate chapters will be devoted to them. A few remains which merely attest to the presence of palatial wings were found at Dagon-Qarantal and Nuseib 'Uweishira to the west of Jericho, and at Hyrcania to the west of the Dead Sea.

This book does not deal with the water projects of the desert fortresses, but it should be mentioned that in effect the water systems at all of these sites have been surveyed and studied, and that almost invariably they are based, as stated above, on the collection of surface runoff with the aid of conduits and local dams. In certain cases the conduits extended over distances of a few kilometers, some of them collecting water that flowed down slopes and others water that flowed in the wadis during rainfalls. The conduits generally extended, with a slight gradient, along contour lines, but in certain localities their course was shortened by means of bridges and tunnels, and at one site (Alexandrium) also with the aid of a siphon. At Cypros too, during its initial construction, a water system based on the same principle was installed. However, during the course of time the Hasmoneans started to build a conduit leading water from the springs of Wadi Qelt to this palatial fortress, a project that was completed only in

Herod's day. All of the sites contained a not inconsiderable number of cisterns which were hewn into the bedrock, usually on the slopes at the foot of the palatial fortress. These systems generally indicate a high standard of hydraulic technology.³

We shall now briefly survey the desert fortresses, proceeding in geographical order from north to south.

Alexandrium

Alexandrium, located on a mountaintop visible from afar, approximately midway between Jericho and Bet Shean (Scythopolis), was one of the most important fortresses in this sequence of strongholds. It undoubtedly played a significant role in protecting the main road from Judaea to the Galilee, as is evident from the many historical events that took place here. It should be mentioned that Josephus' first reference to Herod's building activity is in connection with the dispatch of the young king's brother Pheroras to fortify Alexandrium at a time when Herod himself was engaged in a difficult struggle with Mattathias Antigonus, the *de facto* ruler of Judaea in those years (37-40 B.C.E.).⁴ The remains of impressive walls, probably those of the Hasmonean fortifications, were exposed

Fig. 82 A hall (or peristyle courtyard) revealed on the summit of Alexandrium.

Fig. 83 Qarantal as seen from the Plain of Jericho, viewed from the east.

on the summit of the mountain at the beginning of this century.⁵ On the other hand, the excavations of Tsafrir and Magen on the mountain slope, on the side facing a breathtaking view of the Jordan Valley, exposed a peristyle courtyard, or alternatively a hall measuring 9.6x9.6 m (Fig. 82). These excavations were conducted in the years 1980 and 1982.⁶ The columns, in the Corinthian style (with heart-shaped columns in the corners) were painted red, green, and black, and the courtyard was paved with mosaics. Next to the walls were found the remains of the colored plaster and stucco-work that had originally adorned them. In any event, the excavators ascribed the courtyard to the Herodian period. Above the courtyard, on the western slope of the mountain, was revealed a vaulted structure (cistern?) that served as the base of a terrace higher than the courtyard. All of those remains, as well as the discovery of Corinthian capitals on the surface nearby, led Tsafrir and Magen to suggest the possible existence here of a structure similar to the Northern Palace at Masada (see below, Chapter 11).

It is important to mention that some of the columns of the peristyle courtyard were put to secondary use in architectural elements of Doric style, and parts of Doric columns were found below the courtyard's floor. The remains of a small vaulted cistern, predating the construction of the courtyard, were also revealed beneath it. According to the excavators, these remains belong to an earlier building from the Hasmonean period, thus indicating that in this period too there were lavish wings at Alexandrium. Further excavations at this site will certainly arouse great interest.

Dagon (Qarantal)

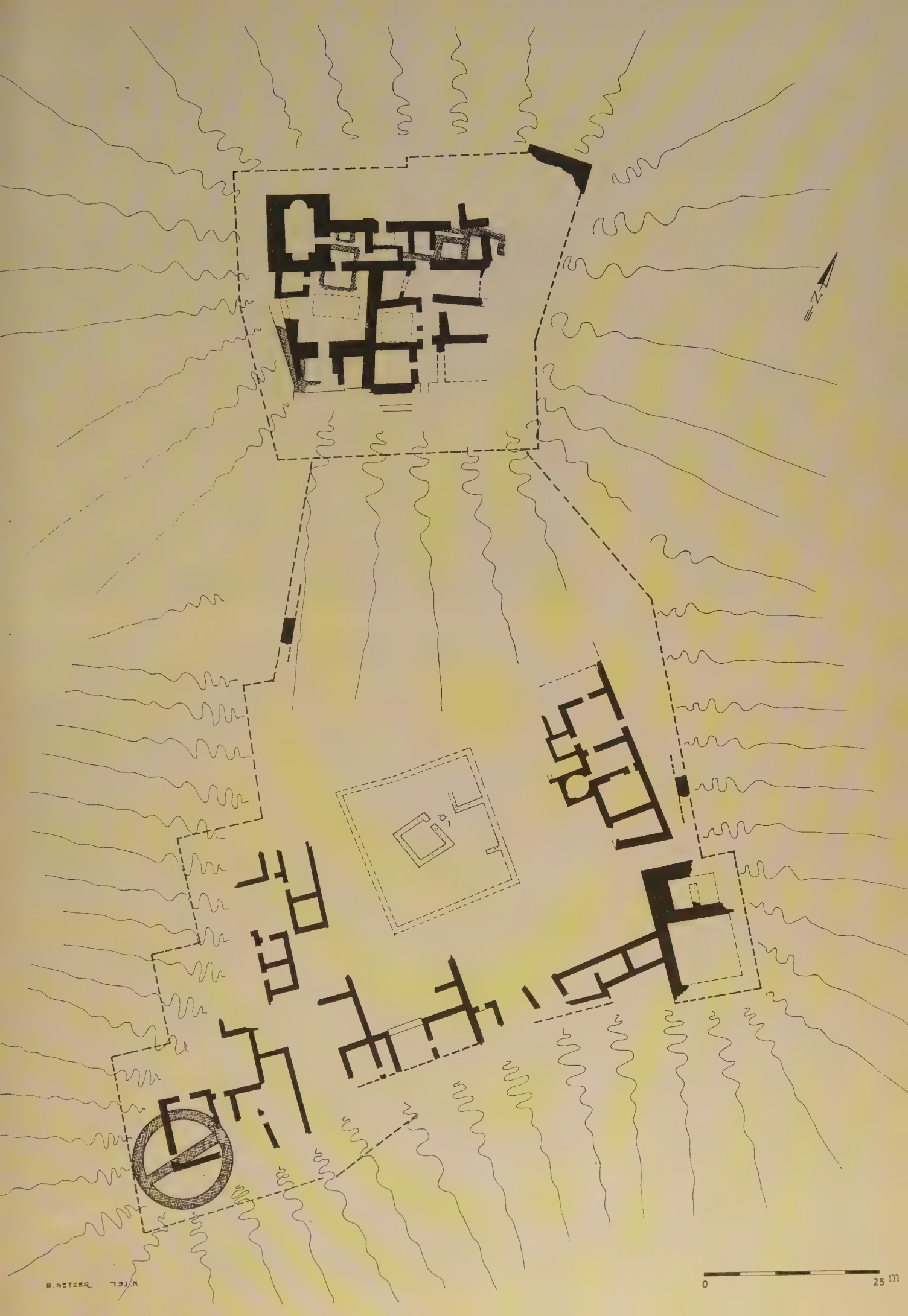
Another palatial fortress existed to the west of Jericho, on the summit of a mountain termed Mons Quarantana (Mountain of the Forty) in Christian tradition and today known as Qarantal, a corruption of the word *quaranta* in Italian (Fig. 83). This mountain commands an extensive view and is today surrounded by an enclosure wall built prior to World War I to protect the church whose construction was never complet-

ed. This is the site termed Docus in the Book of Maccabees and Dagon by Josephus.⁷ The name Docus has been preserved to the present day in Ein Diyuk, one of the three springs in the Na'aran valley (see above, Chapter 2). It should be mentioned that both the Book of Maccabees and Josephus relate of a political assassination that took place in this fortress when Ptolemy son of Habubu, governor of Jericho on behalf of the Maccabees, murdered Simeon, the last of the Maccabean brothers, at a banquet held in the latter's honor. This account serves as indirect evidence of the palatial wings which once existed here.⁸ To the present day no real excavations have been carried out at Qarantal, but the capitals and the architectural elements scattered on the surface indicate the splendor of the buildings that once stood here. A few other signs of the

Fig. 84 *Cypros viewed from the east (from the winter palace complex).*

Fig. 85 *General plan of Cypros (black - Herodian; hatched - Hasmonean; dotted - Byzantine).*





magnificence of this site, as well as evidence of its continued existence in the days of Herod, were revealed in limited soundings conducted by the present author.⁹

Nuseib 'Uweishira

During the course of our work at the winter palace site, we also carried out limited excavations at a site known to the local inhabitants as Nuseib 'Uweishira. This small tell-shaped site is located atop the mountain to the north of Wadi Qelt, immediately above the site of the winter palaces. The main finds revealed here were from the Byzantine period – remains of a small monastery of the *coenobium* type. However, a surprise awaited us here when a few remains from the days of Herod were uncovered below the ruins of the monastery. These remains can be associated with another, previously unknown, fortress. Noteworthy among the meager finds was a stepped pool – a ritual bath (*mikveh*) or part of a bathhouse. The presence of a moat on the site's western side, separating the mountaintop from the rest of the range and enhancing its defensibility, suggests that the original settlement on this mountain dates to the time of the Hasmoneans. To the best of our knowledge, it was the Hasmoneans, and not Herod, who utilized the moat system for defense purposes.¹⁰

Cypros

A surprising picture was revealed at Cypros, directly opposite and to the south of Nuseib 'Uweishira, on the southern side of Wadi Qelt (Figs. 84, 85). The present author, together with E. Damati, conducted the excavations here in 1974.¹¹ Cypros occupies a commanding position overlooking the Jerusalem-Jericho road along Wadi Qelt, close to

the road descending from Jerusalem to Jericho above this wadi. This ancient road, today serving as a tourist trail, was improved during the Roman period and remained the only route linking the two cities until after World War I. The for-

trass was built in the days of the Hasmoneans but was destroyed by Pompey in 63 B.C.E. (see below) and later rebuilt by Herod who named it after his mother Cypros, of Nabatean stock. Most of the finds here belong to the Herodian peri-



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Fig. 86 Part of a Corinthian capital, apparently belonging to the Hasmonean fortress, exposed on the mountaintop at Cypros.

Fig. 87 Remains of the hypocaust below the caldarium on the mountaintop at Cypros.

Fig. 88 Remains of the caldarium revealed on the mountaintop at Cypros.